Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <filen>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

`v3wd` – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type defin
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change
Alt-e – move to end of parent n
Alt-b – move to start of parent
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between ancho
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
% – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal dire
Alt-o – expand selection syntax
Alt-i – shrink selection
; – collapse selection(s) to c
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside t
w / W – word / WORD
p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pair
m – closest surround pair
f – function
t – type or class
a – argument/parameter
c – comment
T – test
g – change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / W
e / E – to end of current word /
b / B – to start of current word
x – current line, extend by l
X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
]p – to next paragraph
[p – to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to pare
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree objec
Alt-p – select previous sibling n
```

```
.  – any character
*  – zero or more
+  – one or more
?  – zero or one / lazy match
^  – start of line / negation in class
$  – end of line
( ) – capture group
[ ] – character class
{ } – repetition count
|  – alternation
\  – escape character itself
```

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

```
        u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s,
                2m, 3h, 4d)
   <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
         Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.3.2 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
        :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
       :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.3.3 Files

```
    :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
    :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

   :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
   :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
         ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
         ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
          gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

          ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
          ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
          ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
    <enter> – open selected in current view
     Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
     Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.3.4 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
        :n – create new scratch buffer
       :bc – close current buffer
      :bca – close all buffers
      :bco – close all but current buffer
       :bn – next buffer
        ␣b – open buffer picker

        ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
        gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
        gn – go to next buffer
        gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.3.5 Views

```
     Alt-n – select next sibling node
     Alt-a – select all sibling nodes i
     Alt-I – select all children nodes
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
  f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
  t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
       Alt-.   – repeat last find / till
```

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
        v – toggle select mode
      Esc – return to normal
        ) – cycle primary selection
        ( – cycle primary selection
   Alt-,  – remove primary selectio
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
  s<regex> – matches become selecti
        S – split on match
     Alt-s – split on newlines
 C / Alt-C – add selection below / ab
```

2.7.2 Operations

```
         & – align on primary cursor
 Alt-<minus> – merge selections
 Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selec
         ,  – remove all except prima
     Alt-,  – remove primary selectio
     ( / )  – rotate primary backwar
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backwar
         K – keep selections matchin
     Alt-K – remove selections matc
```

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

```
        i – before selection
        a – after selection
        I – at start of line
        A – at end of line
        o – add line and insert belo
        O – add line and insert abov
      Esc – end insert (return to no
        . – repeat last insert
```

2.8.2 Add

```
       ]␣ – newline below
       [␣ – newline above
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around s
```

2.8.3 Delete

```
        d – selection -> yank buf, de
```

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
         ␣wq – close current split
         ␣wo – close all but current split
         ␣ww – next split

   ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L  – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
         ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
           Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

       zz, zc – align to center
          zt – align to top
          zb – align to bottom
          zm – align to middle horizontally
          zj – scroll down
          zk – scroll up
```

2.3.6 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
     h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
      gh, g| – beginning of line
      <nn>g| – column <nn>
          gl – end of line
          gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
          ge – bottom of file
          gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

          g.– to last modification in current file
          gj – down textual line
          gk – up textual line

          gs – first non-white-space char
          gt – top of screen
          gc – middle of screen
          gb – bottom of screen
```

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
          gd – go to definition
          gy – go to type definition
          gr – go to references
          gi – go to implementation

          ]d – next diagnostic
          [d – prior diagnostic
          ]D – last diagnostic
          [D – first diagnostic
```

```
       Alt-d – delete, no save
    md<ch> – delete delim <ch> aroun
```

2.8.4 Change

```
           c – selection -> yank buf, ch
      Alt-c – change, no save
           = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
           > – Indent line(s) containing
           < – Undent line(s) containin
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
           ~ – change case
           ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
     Ctrl-a – increment the selected
     Ctrl-x – decrement the selected
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
           J – join lines in a selection
       Alt-J – join lines inside selecti
    <under> – trim whitespace from s
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <wid
       :sort – sort ranges in selection
     :format – format file using exter
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
           y – selection -> yank buf
           p – paste yank buf after the
           P – paste yank buf before th
          ␣y – yank selection(s) -> syst
          ␣Y – yank main selection -> s
    ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / b
          ␣R – replace selection(s) with
       r<ch> – replace selection with <
           R – replace selection with y
           " – select register to yank t
```

ition

ode in syntax tree
node in syntax tree

or and cursor

r
ction (cursor at end)
-aware

ursor(s)

the object indicated by <ch> below:

rs

WORD
WORD
/ WORD
ine

ent syntax node
ct selection
node in syntax tree

2.10 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
    n, N – next, previous match
       * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
  "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
 "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
 "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
 "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
 "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
 "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
 Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
 Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
 Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
     ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
         mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
   Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
   Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

```
     ␣G – debug - experimental
     ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
     ␣s – open document symbol picker
     ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
     ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
     ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
     ␣r – rename symbol
     ␣a – apply code action
     ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.17 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
```

in syntax tree
n syntax tree
s in syntax tree

forward
backward
on

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ons

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ctions
ry selection
on
rds / forwards
d / forward
g the regex
hing the regex

w cursor
e cursor
rmal)

election

lete selection

`:config-open-workspace` – open the workspace config file
`:config-reload` – reload the config file

2.18 Miscellaneous

`␣'` – open last picker
`␣/` – open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	insert new line
`<Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>, <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>`	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close prompt
`<enter>`	open selected
`<tab>`	select next completion item
`<backtab>`	select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	backward a char
`Alt-f`	forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	select next history
`Ctrl-r`	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>`	previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>`	next entry
`<Home>`	to first entry
`<End>`	to last entry
`Ctrl-u, <PageUp>`	page up
`Ctrl-d, <PageDown>`	page down
`<enter>`	open selected
`Alt-<enter>`	open selected in the background without closing the picker
`Ctrl-s`	open horizontally
`Ctrl-v`	open vertically
`Ctrl-t`	toggle preview
`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

d selection

ange selection

n <ch2>

g selection
ng selection

number
number

on and select the inserted space
selection
th>, default 80
n
nal formatter / language server

cursor
he cursor
em clipboard
system clipboard
efore selections(s)
clipboard
ch>
ank buf
o or paste from

```
      Ctrl-u – scroll up
      Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
        <enter> – close menu and accept completion
         Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
        Alt-p – previous signature
        Alt-n – next signature
```